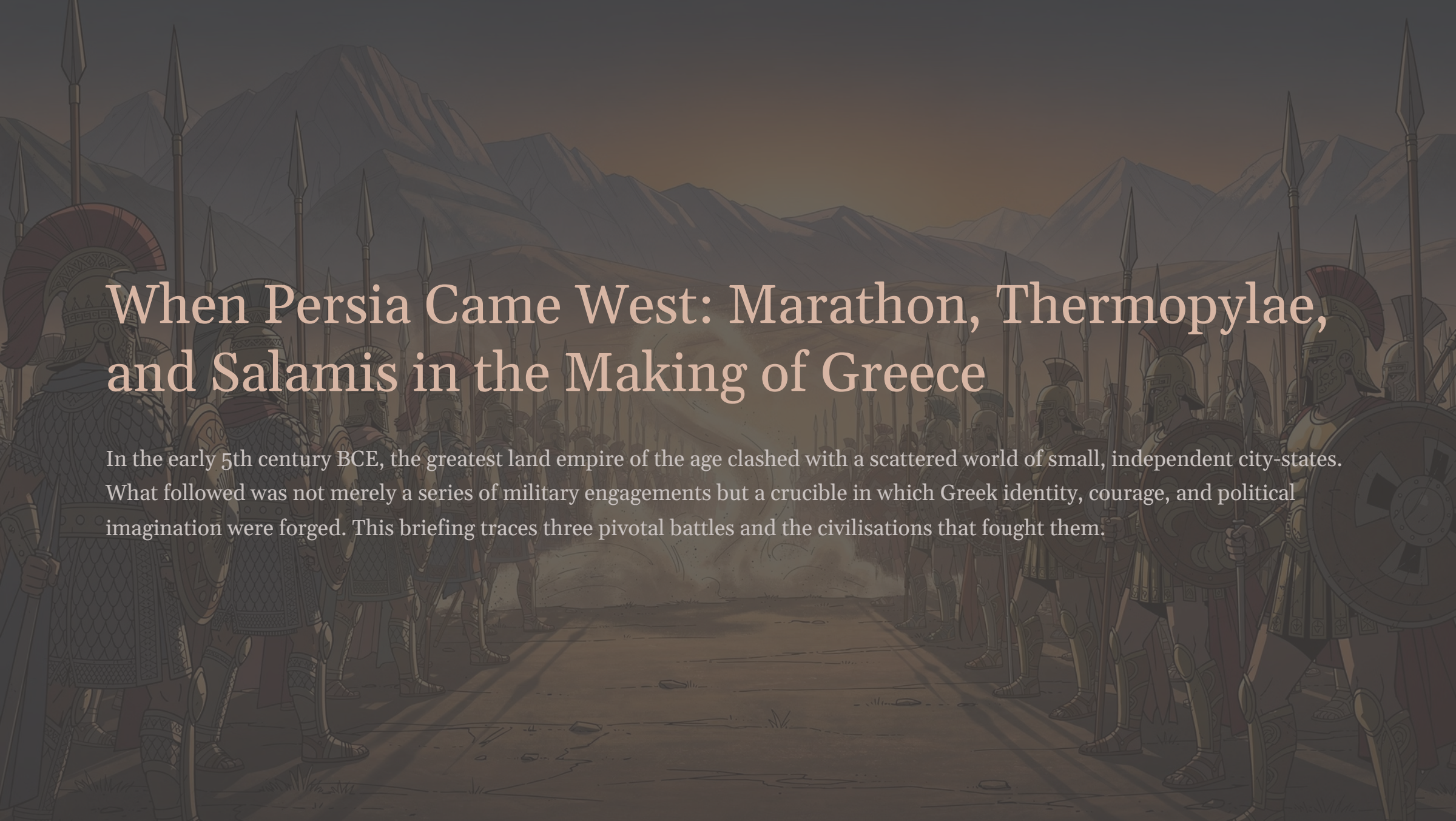


Fires of Freedom: The Wars That Forged Greece

Marathon, Thermopylae and Salamis

© 2026 hijacker9173. All rights reserved.



An illustration of Greek hoplites in a mountainous landscape. The soldiers are shown in profile, wearing helmets with red plumes and carrying spears and shields. They are standing in a line, facing right. The background features a range of mountains under a hazy sky. The overall style is that of a historical illustration or a video game background.

When Persia Came West: Marathon, Thermopylae, and Salamis in the Making of Greece

In the early 5th century BCE, the greatest land empire of the age clashed with a scattered world of small, independent city-states. What followed was not merely a series of military engagements but a crucible in which Greek identity, courage, and political imagination were forged. This briefing traces three pivotal battles and the civilisations that fought them.



Introduction: The Persian Wars and Why These Three Battles

In the early 5th century BCE, the Achaemenid Persian Empire stretched from the Indus River to the Aegean and from Central Asia to Egypt, making it the largest political entity the world had yet seen. Against this colossus stood mainland Greece, politically fragmented into dozens of rival city-states, or *poleis*, each jealously guarding its independence. The conflict between them intensified after the Ionian Revolt, when Athens and Eretria sent ships to assist Ionian Greeks and helped burn Sardis, the wealthy Persian provincial capital. That act brought them into direct confrontation with Achaemenid royal power and set the stage for two decades of war.

The broader Persian Wars ran from 492 to 449 BCE, but Marathon, Thermopylae, and Salamis form the clearest narrative core because each marks a distinct turning point in the struggle. Marathon, fought in 490 BCE, demonstrated that Persian forces could be defeated in open land battle. Thermopylae, in 480 BCE, became the defining story of disciplined resistance and voluntary sacrifice. Salamis, fought just weeks after Thermopylae, broke the momentum of Xerxes' invasion by destroying Persian naval superiority in Greek waters and forcing a strategic withdrawal.

These three engagements also matter because they shaped Greek identity and collective memory for centuries. They were transformed over time from military events into moral lessons about courage, tactical ingenuity, civic unity, and the capacity of free peoples to resist imperial domination. Understanding them is essential to understanding how the Greeks understood themselves.

Marathon, 490 BCE

First proof that Persian armies could be beaten on land by Greek hoplites.

Thermopylae, 480 BCE

The defining act of sacrifice that kept Greek resolve alive in defeat.

Salamis, 480 BCE

The naval turning point that broke Persian strategic momentum.